

MY LOVE DON'T COST A THING

When I'm interested in a new person romantically, my best friend always asks me what the person does for work, and I always resent the question. It's not very exciting to think about the finances of someone you're lusting over. "Why don't you ask me about their radiant smile?" "Or their quick sense of humor?" "Or their adorable pet hedgehog?"

The first time I realized money might factor into a relationship was when I was 24 years old. It was toward the end of my time living in New York City. I freelanced as a day job and then spent the rest of my time at the People's Improv Theater, where I performed on one of the house teams. Improv can be a haven for forever-children: adults who don't want to, or really can't, grow up. In a "comedy pyramid scheme," you had to pay hundreds of dollars to finish level 5 of the courses the theater requires you to take just to audition to do improv for free every week. (The theater charged patrons to attend, but I never saw any of that money.) The first round of classes, my grandmother Meme paid for as a birthday gift. It was about \$400 for eight weeks. The second, third, fourth, and fifth rounds of classes must have gone on my credit card.

Being on an improv team required showing up to shows and rehearsals. My teammates and I paid for a coach and a rehearsal space out of pocket, pooling our money in the pre-Venmo days of cash. That was a job that paid in "stage time," much the way my freelance writing gigs paid in "exposure."

The Netflix animated show *BoJack Horseman* did a great episode basically comparing improv to a cult. Specifically, what it shares with most cults is the people who are most drawn to it are the ones who have no money.

My story was classic New York: I started dating a fellow improviser. He was, like a lot of the other men at the theater, a good amount older than I was, had no steady day job, and was in tons of debt. I was maniacally attracted to him.